C2 Speaking

Telling an engaging anecdote

Tell a short personal story that holds attention, using a hook, vivid detail, suspense and a satisfying ending.

Anecdotes make conversation memorable, and at C2 you are expected to tell them with the timing and colour of a native speaker. The secret is structure: listeners stay with you when they know a story is going somewhere.

Stage	Purpose	Language
Hook	Promise a good story	*You'll never guess what happened to me at the airport.*
Setting	Who, where, when, briefly	*So, this was a few years ago, I was flying back from Istanbul...*
Build-up	Detail and tension	*Everything was going fine until... Out of nowhere,...*
Climax	The key moment	*And then, just as I was about to..., I realised...*
Resolution and point	What happened and why it matters	*In the end,... Looking back, it taught me never to...*

Switch tenses for effect. Many speakers switch to the present at the exciting moment, using the present continuous for the background and the present simple for the events: *So I'm standing there, and this man walks up to me...* It makes the story feel immediate.

Common mistake. Too much background. If the setting takes longer than the event, listeners lose interest. Give only the details the ending needs.

Practice

1. Write a hook for a story about getting lost in a foreign city.

2. Set the scene in one sentence: who, where, when.
3. Build suspense with "Everything was going fine until...".
4. Retell the climax in the present simple: I opened the door and saw a camel in the garden.
5. End with the point of the story.

▼ **Show answers**

1. Have I ever told you about the night I got completely lost in Tokyo?
2. So, it was my first trip to Japan, about five years ago, and I was on my own.
3. Everything was going fine until my phone died, and I couldn't read a single street sign.
4. So I open the door, and there's a camel standing in the middle of the garden.
5. Looking back, it taught me to always carry a paper map and a power bank.